



women's football. HOPS FC also dropped down after finishing last.

Odisha managed just three wins from its 14 matches. Head coach Crispin Chettri — who is also in charge of the Indian women's national team — will now shift focus to leading the Blue Tigresses in the AFC Women's Asia Cup 2026 Qualifiers, scheduled between June and July.

Churchill crowned but drama continues

The air of uncertainty surrounding the I-League 2024–25 winner was cleared nearly a fortnight after the season's conclusion when the All India Football Federation's (AIFF) Appeals Committee declared Churchill Brothers as the champion.

The controversy centred on three points initially awarded to Inter Kashi by the AIFF, despite a loss, after a Namdhari FC player was deemed ineligible for a match between the two sides back in January. However,

Joyous moment: The Red and Gold Brigade romped to the title and lost just once en route to a spot in the preliminary stage of the AFC Women's Champions League. EAST BENGAL FC

the federation overturned its own decision in March following Namdhari's appeal, thereby revoking the three points from Kashi.

Inter Kashi is now set to challenge the Appeals Committee's ruling at the Court of Arbitration for Sport. "From the very beginning, Inter Kashi has been clear that the case involves a simple interpretation of rules and regulations based on some undisputed facts. Inter Kashi will leave no stone unturned to secure justice, and any celebration in the interim may ultimately prove to be premature," the club stated.

In I-League 2, Diamond Harbour FC from West Bengal clinched the title after having already confirmed promotion to the I-League. Chanmari FC from Aizawl also earned promotion to the country's second tier.

Super Cup begins with Asia spot at stake

While East Bengal's women's team prepares to shine on the continental stage, the men's team had a below-par 2024–25 season,

which ended with elimination in the Super Cup. The defending champion was knocked out in the Round of 16 after a 0–2 loss to Kerala Blasters.

The Yellow Army will face Mohun Bagan Super Giant in the quarterfinals after the Mariners received a bye in the first round due to Churchill Brothers opting out of the competition, citing the earlier uncertainty regarding the I-League title.

FC Goa and Punjab FC also advanced to the last eight after beating Gokulam Kerala and Odisha FC, respectively. Winning the Super Cup will grant the champion a place in the qualifying playoffs of the AFC Champions League Two.

Interest expressed to host 2031 Asian Cup

The AIFF has submitted India's Expression of Interest (EoI) to host the 2031 edition of the AFC Asian Cup. Indonesia and Kuwait have also submitted EoIs, alongside a joint bid from Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan. India has never hosted the tournament, though it had previously submitted bids to host the 2023 and 2027 editions.

Contrasting fortunes: East Bengal was knocked out by Kerala Blasters (in pic) in the Super Cup. AIFF MEDIA

